



TMC221

Lecture 3

Personal Branding and Strategic Positioning

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You Already Have a Brand

The Brand You Never Built — But Already Own

Your brand is what people say about you when you are not in the room. — **Jeff Bezos**

- Every interaction is a data point
- Every action is a vote for who you are
- Silence is not neutrality — it is invisibility
- **The question is not whether you have a brand. It is whether you control it.**

Why Now?

The Tunde & Emeka Problem

- *Same grade. Same university. One job offer.*
- Both graduated with a **2:1** in Engineering.
- One had spoken at project week, published on LinkedIn, and led his faculty society.
- The other had the same intelligence — and **zero** professional visibility.
- The hiring manager already knew one name before the interview
- Grades were equal. Visibility was not.
- **Your undergraduate years are not a waiting room. They are a brand-building laboratory.**

The Cup Analogy

Clean the Inside First

First clean the inside of the cup and dish, and then the outside also will be clean. — Matthew 23:25–26

- The Pharisees perfected **external** presentation while masking **internal** emptiness.
- **The Lesson:** A brand built on performance without substance collapses under real scrutiny.
- **Before packaging, there must be something worth packaging.**

The 3 Dimensions of Inner Brand

What Cleaning the Inside Actually Looks Like

A good tree cannot bear bad fruit. — **Matt 7:18**

- **Clarify your Values** — What would you refuse to compromise even if it cost you?
- **Have Character Consistency** — Are you the same person with the professor and with the security guard?
- **Build Competence Depth** — Every skill sharpened is a deposit the brand will one day withdraw.
- **Brand output is fruit. Fruit does not lie about the tree.**

The Self-Audit

Know Thyself Before You Brand Thyself

Start here: Ask three trusted people — "*What three words describe me professionally?*" Their answers are more accurate than your assumptions.

Question	What It Reveals
What do I do exceptionally well?	Your zone of strength
What do I care about deeply?	Your brand energy
What do others consistently say about me?	Your external reality
Where do I want to go?	Your strategic direction

Brand Pillars

Self-Knowledge to Brand Architecture

Meet Adaeze. 300-Level Computer Science.

- Strong in UI/UX. Passionate about rural tech access. Known for explaining complexity simply.
- Her self-audit produced four clear pillars: **Design Thinking | Social Impact | Communication | Tech for Good**
- Every project, every application, every conversation now serves a coherent identity.
- She stopped trying to be everyone's candidate. She became **Unmistakably herself.**

Packaging — Three Levels

From Substance to Signal

Great character poorly communicated = **Invisible**

- **Personal Presentation** — How you dress, carry yourself, and occupy a room. Your presence speaks before your mouth opens.
- **Professional Documentation** — Your CV is not a list. It is a curated narrative. *Every line must earn its place.*
- **Digital Presence** — Recruiters search you before they meet you. What they find is already forming an impression.

Packaging is not deception. It is **Translation.**

LinkedIn — Your Most Important Real Estate



The Platform Working for You **24 Hours a Day**

Your profile needs at **minimum**:

- A professional headshot
- A headline that captures your brand — not just your **degree**
- A **summary** that communicates vision and value
- Projects, Leadership Roles, and Achievements
- **Beyond LinkedIn:** GitHub for tech. Personal site for media. Industry engagement everywhere.

Old posts are
Brand Liabilities.
Digital hygiene
is brand
hygiene.



AFRICAN
LEADERSHIP
DEVELOPMENT
CENTRE

Positioning

You Are Not Competing for Jobs.
You Are Competing for **Mindshare**.

Companies don't compete in the marketplace — they compete in the minds of consumers. — **Al Ries & Jack Trout**

- Being equally known for 5 things = Memorable for none of them.
- **Depth of Focus → Distinction → Recall → Opportunity**
- When a specific opening arises — does your name come to mind?

Finding Your Niche

A Niche Is Not a Limitation — It Is a Launch Pad

The Generalist

Competes in a crowded market

Forgettable across many fields

Available

The Specialist

Occupies a specific lane

Memorable in one domain

Sought after

The question to answer before graduation:

Within my field, what is the one area I want to be the go-to person for?

Networking

Your Network Is a Multiplier

NETWORKING is not collecting contacts or attending events for free food. It is the cultivation of genuine, mutually beneficial relationships with people doing work that matters.

On Mentors:

- They compress timelines and shortcut costly mistakes
- To attract one, demonstrate you are already in motion
- Don't wait to be assigned — pursue one
- **The worst they can say is no.**

The Brand Bank Account

Every Day Is a Transaction

Deposits

Withdrawals

Acts of excellence

Unreliability

Integrity under pressure

Poor-quality output

Fulfilled promises

Public negativity

Showing up consistently

Treating "unimportant" people poorly

-  **Reputations are built in the ordinary moments — not the dramatic ones.**
-  The greatest threat to your brand is not failure — it is **Invisibility.**

Authenticity

One Person. Every Room.

The student who is respectful to professors but dismissive to staff, ambitious in interviews but passive in class, values-driven online but compromising in private — is not building a brand. **They are performing one.**

- **Authenticity is integration:**
When private and public align; when words, actions, and values are the same person — you produce what no strategy can manufacture: **Trustworthiness.**

Whatever you do, whether in word or deed, do it all in the name of the Lord Jesus — **Col 3:17**

Conclusion — Your Next Seven Days

The Brand Starts Today

- Complete your **self-audit** — four questions, two honest pages
- Write your **brand statement** — 100 words, true enough to say out loud
- Optimise your **LinkedIn Profile** — headline, headshot, summary
- Ask 3 people — "What three words describe me professionally?"
- Identify **one mentor** to pursue this semester
- **The cup is yours to clean. The brand is yours to build.**

Thank You
Questions *and*
Comments

